

EU Commission ignored its own advice before weakening car CO2 rules

送信者: POLITICO Pro Article 受信日時: 2026-09-28 14:01

【要点】

- ・ EU委員会は、2035年の自動車CO2排出禁止ルールを弱めるべきではないという独自の内部助言を無視して、自動車メーカーと各国政府の圧力に屈した。
- ・ 内部文書は、ドイツなど強力な加盟国とEPP、および自動車業界からの政治的圧力を受けて、2023年に採択されたEUの規制を後退させたことを示している。
- ・ 委員会の分析官は、電気自動車の販売低迷を理由に2035年目標の達成が不可能だという主張は時期尚早であり、政策変更は投資家への悪いシグナルになると警告していた。
- ・ 自動車メーカーは規制見直しを2026年から2025年に前倒しするよう働きかけ、2025年目標達成の失敗に対して約150億ユーロの罰金リスクに直面していると主張していた。
- ・ EU委員会はこの内部文書についてのコメントを拒否し、「内部文書には応じない」と述べている。

【メール原文】

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EU Commission ignored its own advice before weakening car CO2 rules

By Jordyn Dahl · Sep 28, 2026, 7:00 AM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — The European Commission ignored its own advice to hold the line on slashing emissions from cars before caving in to automakers and powerful national capitals, according to an internal briefing document obtained by POLITICO .

Despite the internal advice, the Commission backtracked on the EU's effective ban on the sale of new CO2-emitting cars from 2035 — legislation adopted in 2023 that was once considered a key part of the Green Deal.

The decision came following fierce political pressure from Germany and allied capitals, as well as from the center-right European People's Party, the political family to which Commission President Ursula von der Leyen belongs, and the car industry.

Although the briefing document dates from early 2025, it lands amid ongoing political negotiations over whether the EU should further loosen car CO2 rules, with European automakers under growing pressure from Chinese rivals.

The internal Commission document was prepared ahead of a January 2025 meeting between Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra and representatives of car lobby ACEA and car parts supplier association

CLEPA.

It warned that it was too early to call the 2035 target unachievable, despite arguments from European carmakers that they needed relief because of sluggish electric vehicle sales.

The document also warned that changing the policy would send a negative signal to companies that had invested billions in ramping up EV production.

“It is premature and speculative to draw any conclusion on specific compliance situations,” said the document prepared by analysts with the Directorate General for Climate Action. “For our future industrial competitiveness, it is extremely important to continue providing certainty to the market and investors.”

The briefing paper was obtained by climate investigations NGO Aria through a freedom of information request.

The Commission declined to respond, saying it does not comment on internal documents or internal preparatory decisions.

Slashing emissions

The EU passed the de facto combustion engine ban in 2023, requiring a 100% reduction in tailpipe emissions from new cars by 2035.

A review of the regulation was set for 2026, but automakers and their suppliers lobbied hard for the Commission to move the review to 2025, arguing that EV sales had stalled in 2024, which would make the legislation’s targets impossible to meet.

The companies said they risked paying €15 billion in fines for failing to meet the 2025 target, which stipulated that carmakers reduce emissions by 15 percent in 2025 from a 2021 baseline or be fined €95 per gram of CO₂ per kilometer emitted above the target for each noncompliant vehicle sold in the bloc.

But DG CLIMA was skeptical of those claims.

“This amount claimed by the industry represents the very unlikely case of ‘no action’ and absolutely no improvement from any of the manufacturers,” it wrote in the briefing document.

DG CLIMA also pointed to growing EV sales and argued that electrification was crucial to Europe’s global competitiveness.

“The automotive market is global, and recent developments show that the future competitiveness of industry on the global stage is linked to new powertrain technologies (electric),” the note said.

Ahead of the Hoekstra meeting, DG CLIMA dismissed the plea for leniency, writing in the note that “we should stick to” the initial timeline.

Automotive analysts and green groups agreed, saying European carmakers would meet the 2025 targets thanks to the new all-electric and hybrid models that were expected to hit the market that year.

They were proven correct. EV sales surged 30% in 2025, growing to 1.88 million, ACEA data showed .

However, the DG CLIMA document did not sway the Commission as it gave way to the combined pressure from member countries — led by Germany and including Bulgaria, the Czech Republic, Hungary, Italy, Poland and Slovakia — as well as the car industry to modify the 2035 law.

Hoekstra's meeting was part of a longer process led by von der Leyen and was a major priority for the Commission president. She hosted the CEOs of Europe's automakers and suppliers in two strategic dialogues.

In the first dialogue, held two weeks after DG CLIMA sent its internal memo, von der Leyen told the group that she would move the legislation's review forward to 2025, a participant told POLITICO.

Those discussions laid the groundwork for her Automotive Action Plan presented in March 2025. In December 2025, the Commission proposed watering down the EU ban .

Under the proposal, instead of reducing tailpipe emissions from new vehicles by 100 percent by 2035, automakers would now only have to lower them by 90 percent from 2021 levels. Carmakers would have to compensate for the remaining emissions through the use of low-carbon steel, e-fuels or biofuels.

That proposal is now being debated by EU institutions.

The pressure hasn't stopped. Automakers and their political allies are now lobbying to weaken the rules even further as competition from Chinese carmakers intensifies and European manufacturers such as Volkswagen cut jobs and close factories.

The EPP, which campaigned on overturning the ban, is the lead negotiator on the issue in the European Parliament. Its draft report goes even further than industry demands, effectively lowering the targets to a 73% emissions cut by giving larger offsets through alternative fuels and green steel.

That's dismaying climate campaigners.

The EPP proposal "combines the worst ideas of the auto, oil and biofuel lobbies. The result is a law where carmakers could comply without selling a single electric car in 2035," said William Todts, executive director of green NGO Transport & Environment.

Mobility Energy and Climate Competition and Industrial Policy Sustainability

Cars Competition and Industrial Policy Electric vehicles Emissions road transport emissions Ursula von der Leyen Wopke Hoekstra European Commission European Parliament European People's Party (EPP) Volkswagen Germany

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